

to stop water from being lost to his neighbors' crops, and who is in love with the village girl whom his brother marries. Shot in shimmering black and white, the movie elevates melodrama into poetry.

JASON AND THE ARGONAUTS

Don Chaffey, 1963

Underpinned by Bernard Herrmann's stirring brass music, Don Chaffey's movie makes the most of Ray Harryhausen's stop-motion animation of clay models to bring to life the story of Jason, the hero of Greek mythology who led his crew, the Argonauts, on a quest for the legendary Golden Fleece. Harryhausen's animations have a distinctive style, and his army of skeletons rising from the ground is impressive even today. Seen on the big screen in full color and sound, *Jason and the Argonauts* remains a genuinely stirring epic.

ONIBABA

Kaneto Shindo, 1964

Kaneto Shindo's *Onibaba* works both as a horror movie and a period drama. It tells the story of a mother and daughter who set traps and murder samurai in order to survive during a time of civil war in 14th-century Japan. Shot in a decidedly chilling black and white, it is a parable of the suffering undergone by all the innocent bystanders throughout history. When the old woman kills one samurai, she pulls off his mask to find his face disfigured like a *hibakusha* (a victim of the nuclear bomb). When she wears the mask, her face becomes disfigured too.

I AM CUBA

Mikhail Kalatozov, 1964

Hidden away in Soviet archives for three decades, Kalatozov's *I Am Cuba* was restored following a campaign led by US director Martin Scorsese in the 1990s. A joint Soviet–Cuban production, it was not well received on release, and had been mostly forgotten. Yet the movie is an extraordinary document of its time, telling the story of oppressed peasants in 1950s Cuba, and their resistance, spurred on by the hope that Fidel Castro's revolution would bring a brighter future. The movie is now also celebrated for its extraordinary tracking shots in which the camera seems to float magically about—an effect achieved by strapping the camera to the cameraman's waist and moving him along a carefully linked set of pulleys.

CLOSELY OBSERVED TRAINS

Jirí Menzel, 1966

Set in Nazi-occupied Czechoslovakia, Jirí Menzel's *Closely Observed Trains* (known in the US as *Closely Watched Trains*) is a wry and touching look at the perils of sexual awakening. The grim realities of war are never far away as young station guard Miloš strives to lose his virginity, but Menzel's witty screenplay, inspired by Bohumil Hrabal's book, keeps the focus firmly on a universal human problem. Like other movies of the Czech New Wave, the movie serves as a reminder to Czechs of the brutalizing effects of the system under which they live, but the tone is sardonic and gentle rather than strident.

PERSONA

Ingmar Bergman, 1966

Persona, by Swedish director Ingmar Bergman, is an intense psychological drama that turns into a horror movie as the central relationship unravels. A young nurse (Bibi Andersson) is assigned to take care of a well-known actress (Liv Ullmann), who has mysteriously become mute. To fill the silence, the nurse confides in her about her life, including having an abortion as a young girl. But things turn nasty when the nurse discovers the actress has been psychoanalyzing her. The actress's silent rejection of the gender-restrictive roles of motherhood and nursing is, some critics believe, the focus of the movie, but it also explores the bleakness of illness and madness. **See also:** *The Seventh Seal* 136–39

THE GRADUATE

Mike Nichols, 1967

At the time it was released, *The Graduate* seemed daring in its subject matter, dealing as it does with intergenerational sex. Young college graduate Benjamin Braddock (Dustin Hoffman) embarks upon a sexual relationship with Mrs. Robinson (Anne Bancroft) and then falls in love with her daughter Elaine Robinson (Katherine Ross), when he. The apparently conventional happy ending, in which Benjamin stops Elaine from marrying the wrong man and escapes with her on a bus, is not quite what it seems. The movie deliberately aimed to tap into youth culture with its iconic sound track (by Simon and Garfunkel), setting a trend for youth movies.